I’m Not Angry

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INT. RDP HOUSE – AFTERNOON

The door opens. Xiluva(19) steps in, hesitant. A year away. Her parents(late 40s) and three siblings(aged, 15,13&9) light up.

YOUNGER SIBLING

Sisi! You're back! What did you bring?

SIBLING 2

You look so light… you're glowing.

The siblings rush to hug her. Her parents remain seated. They smile. Greet her casually. Xiluva hugs back, but her eyes are already scanning the house and they land on, the not-so-clean cabinets, a pot with dried-up soup on the stove, and a broken chair in the corner. Something is off. The SOUND of the house begins to creep in.

INT. HOUSE – CONTINUOUS

Xiluva moves toward the kids' room. The camera follows closely. Slightly unstable.

XILUVA

Leave the phones. Let's clean up first. I need space to unpack.

The kids hesitate… then slowly follow. The room is worse. The wardrobe has no door. Inside one of the shelves there's a small toiletries section with two worn-out toothbrushes in cups, a nearly finished, brandless toothpaste and a thin bar of soap. Xiluva picks it up.

XILUVA

Do you guys have soap?

OLDER SIBLING

No.

XILUVA

Dawn?

OLDER SIBLING

(shakes head)

No.

The SOUND grows louder, not aggressive, just overwhelming. Xiluva moves out.

INT. KITCHEN – CONTINUOUS

She opens the fridge. Inside there's 2L Coca-Cola bottles filled with water, and half an onion. She stares. Opens the cabinet filled with dust and unused plastic containers. The younger sibling appears beside her, wiping their nose with a cloth. Lingering. Repetitive.

Xiluva closes the fridge and opens the freezer and it's empty. She turns. Her mother is in the other room busy on her phone, playing slots, tapping, waiting, and hoping. Xiluva walks towards her.

INT. LIVING AREA – CONTINUOUS

XILUVA
What are we eating tonight?

MOTHER
Bread.

XILUVA
When did He last go to look for a job?

MOTHER
He's tired of always looking.

XILUVA
Why not go back to the local butcher?

MOTHER
They pay peanuts there.

The TV flickers. The sound of the TV, the fridge HUM, clicks and distant buzzing layers more. Xiluva turns. Walks away, the younger sibling behind her.

INT. KIDS' ROOM – CONTINUOUS

XILUVA
(Looking at the older sibling)

Did mom buy the uniform… the one I sent money for?

OLDER SIBLING
Mhhm-mmm(No). (Xiluva exhales and goes back to the kitchen)

INT. KITCHEN – CONTINUOUS

XILUVA

The money I sent… what did you do with it, Nathi still doesn’t have her uniform.

MOTHER

Things got hard. We couldn’t pay rent. I used it on food.

XILUVA

(looking around)
I sent it 2 weeks back. There’s no food in the house.

MOTHER

I’m feeding five people. It’s not enough. It doesn’t even last a week.

Xiluva averts her eyes at the sight of her mother’s now angry face, and they land on a Betway receipt on the counter.

XILUVA

But there’s money for Betway?

There’s silence for a few seconds.

MOTHER

(Her voice stern)
You haven’t even been here for a day and already you’re acting like this is not your home.
Things have been hard. I don’t want to deal with your attitude on top of that.

Before Xiluva can respond, the door opens and her father walks in with a bottle of beer, Coca-Cola for the kids and a Betway voucher. And suddenly everything around her becomes louder, and the electricity meter starts beeping.

FATHER

(Looking at Xiluva)
Why are you angry?

All the sound cuts out, and the silence is now heavy.

XILUVA

(Her face full, not angry)

I’m not angry.

The BEEP returns, then silence.